Mubarak Haveli, only to have the Shah choke with tears at the memories his verses stirred. ‘O breeze what have you done to the long hair of my beloved?’ replied Shuja with lines in the same metre.

> You have disturbed the peace of my heart.
>
> The bird of my heart is lamenting the memory of my homeland
> This bulbul is lamenting its separation from the garden.[7]

A few months later, Ranjit Singh decided to seize what was left of Shah Shuja’s treasures. Shuja was invited to take part in a Sikh attack on Peshawar where his estranged brother-in-law Fatteh Khan Barakzai was trying to consolidate his rule. ‘Even though we were then suffering from an extremely sore throat,’ wrote Shuja, ‘we left our ladies encamped in the Shalimar Gardens and set out to join the Sikh by forced marches.’ After Shuja had been lured out of Lahore into the countryside, the campaign was mysteriously called off, ostensibly because Fatteh Khan had withdrawn to Kabul. It was on the return journey that Shuja had his camp plundered by a group of armed robbers who descended on the royal tents in the middle of the night. When one of the dacoits was captured by Shuja’s Afghan bodyguard, he revealed that he was working for Ranjit Singh himself. ‘We were astonished and horrified at this evidence of the heartless treachery of these crass, ignorant Sikh dogs,’ commented Shuja. He then wrote to Ranjit: ‘What sort of behaviour is this? Whatever it is that you are plotting to do, do so openly – but stop this sly and underhand harassment! It is shameful!’

The following evening, the stolen trunks were brought back into the camp. ‘Making a complete uproar, our Sikh escort brought the trunks, carpet bags and treasure chests into Our Royal Presence – all of them empty!’ Shuja lamented:

> Everything was gone, apart from a few old clothes of no particular use. The boxes full of lustrous pearls, the Ottoman and Sindhi guns with gold bands, the fine Persian swords, jewel-encrusted gilt pistols, chests of coins in red and white gold, fine cashmere and silk shawls, all of it gone! And the black-hearted hypocrites had the gall to say to us: ‘Here we bring your possessions, which we’ve fearlessly saved from the robbers! Let His Majesty inspect now to see if anything might by any chance be missing!’ Such shameless robbery, and then the effrontery to protest loyalty: it is quite repulsive! God save us from all such!

Knowing that Ranjit Singh himself was behind the robbery, Shuja added,